

GOLDEN HANDCUFFS

Scorecard + Optionality Plan

A quick check on how much your current life depends on your current job - and what to strengthen next.

01 / SCORE YOURSELF

Circle one score for each statement. Be realistic, not aspirational.

STATEMENT	0	1	2	3
FIXED COSTS My essential monthly expenses are comfortably below my take-home pay, so I could absorb a meaningful income drop without immediate panic.	☐	☐	☐	☐
ACCESSIBLE RUNWAY I have enough accessible cash to cover several months of essential expenses without touching retirement accounts or relying on credit.	☐	☐	☐	☐
BENEFITS DEPENDENCE I understand what would happen to health insurance, retirement benefits, bonuses, equity, and other employer-linked benefits if I left.	☐	☐	☐	☐
CAREER PORTABILITY My skills, reputation, and network would help me earn again outside my current employer, title, or industry.	☐	☐	☐	☐
INCOME DIVERSITY At least some of my financial security exists outside one paycheck - through investments, other income, or assets I can access.	☐	☐	☐	☐
IDENTITY FLEXIBILITY My sense of success is not completely tied to my title, seniority, compensation, or being seen as the person who has it all figured out.	☐	☐	☐	☐
CHOICE If this job stopped fitting my life, I would have enough financial and emotional room to make a thoughtful decision instead of an urgent one.	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING: 0 = not true yet 1 = partly true 2 = mostly true 3 = strongly true

0-7 HIGHLY DEPENDENT Your current job likely controls more of your choices than you want.	8-14 ATTACHED You have some flexibility, but a few dependencies could still narrow your options.	15-21 FLEXIBLE You have meaningful optionality. Keep strengthening the areas that would buy you even more choice.
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YOUR SCORE: ____ / 21

YOUR OPTIONALITY PLAN

You do not need to blow up your life. Build choices before you need them.

02 / CHOOSE YOUR NEXT 3 MOVES

Pick one action in each category for the next 90 days. Small improvements compound into real leverage.

MONEY / Reduce financial dependence on your current income.

- ☐ Calculate your true essential monthly number - not your ideal budget.
- ☐ Build or increase accessible runway by one month of essential expenses.
- ☐ Choose one recurring expense to cut, renegotiate, or avoid upgrading.
- ☐ Direct part of your next raise, bonus, or windfall toward assets or cash instead of permanent lifestyle costs.

CAREER / Make your earning power more portable.

- ☐ Write down the 3-5 skills you could sell outside your current company.
- ☐ Reconnect with three people outside your employer or immediate team.
- ☐ Identify one skill, credential, or portfolio proof that would expand your options.
- ☐ Pressure-test what you could realistically earn if you changed company, role, industry, or work model.

LIFE / Separate what you want from what looks successful.

- ☐ Write what you would choose if your title and salary were invisible to everyone else.
- ☐ Name the one thing you are staying for - money, benefits, identity, timing, fear, or something else.
- ☐ Decide what would need to be true for staying another year to feel intentional.
- ☐ Define what “enough” looks like for this season of your life.

03 / MAKE IT CONCRETE

MY MONEY MOVE

MY CAREER MOVE

MY LIFE MOVE

The question is not “Can I quit tomorrow?”

It is: “Am I building a life where staying is a choice - and leaving could be one too?”

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